
The Women-Led Bid to Build Mexico's First Bitcoin Pueblo Mágico



Karla
Revilla



Alex
Domínguez

Zacatlán de las Manzanas, a Pueblo Mágico in the Sierra Norte of Puebla, is better known for cider, artisanal clocks, and the more than one million visitors who climb into its apple highlands each year. The town has nonetheless set out to become the first Magic Town in Mexico to build a Bitcoin circular economy, and the group steering that effort is UNLOCK Universe, a women-led Web3 and Bitcoin education project.

UNLOCK Universe began in 2022 as a summit and has since grown into a year-round education arm across Mexico and Latin America. Led by co-founder and CEO Karla Revilla and co-founder and CMO Alex Domínguez, UNLOCK's work extends beyond annual events, partnering with governments, universities, and private organizations on technology education initiatives across the region.

In a conversation with Crypto India Magazine, the UNLOCK team explained why they chose a rural mountain town over Mexico City and what it would take for the model to travel.

How UNLOCK Set Out to Bridge Two Worlds

When Revilla describes the origins of the project, she returns to the two years she spent touring events between 2021 and 2022, when she realized an opportunity existed to connect two communities that rarely overlapped.

"There were female leadership events, but without technology. And crypto events, but without women. Nobody was building that bridge," she recalled.

For Revilla, the stakes run deeper than representation, and she frames the entire enterprise as a form of repayment. *"The world owes a financial debt to women, and this technology is the opportunity to pay it off,"* she said, a framing that chimes with a broader shift CIM has tracked, in which women are increasingly driving crypto adoption.

What started as a three-day summit soon surfaced demand that a single event could not contain, as governments, universities, and companies asked UNLOCK to bring technological education into their communities year-round. That pull gave rise to UNLOCK Center, the project's technology arm, which now works with public and private partners across the region, with collaborations reaching as far as India.

Why Zacatlán Became the Bitcoin Test Bed

The decision to anchor the experiment in Zacatlán rather than a metropolis rests on a wager about where adoption takes hold, which is wherever the technology answers a problem people already feel. Steph Serrano, the founder of Escuela Bitcoin México and UNLOCK's Bitcoin lead, contends that the arithmetic favors the periphery over the capital. *"In Mexico City, Bitcoin competes against twenty banking options. In Zacatlán, more than 5,000 adults do not have a bank account: for them it is not an alternative, it is the first option,"* she said. Remittances arriving in the town can carry commissions as high as 12 percent, she added, even as roughly 92 percent of residents already carry the needed infrastructure in a smartphone.

The team treats the Bitcoin community on Isla Mujeres as a proof of concept worth studying, crediting BTC Isla with signing more than 40 businesses inside two years through patient, door-to-door outreach and in-person classes. In Zacatlán, UNLOCK is adapting that playbook, dispatching educational brigades to merchants and residents while running a route through five local universities so students leave better prepared for a digitized economy.

How the 2025 Summit Laid the Groundwork

The first UNLOCK Summit held in Zacatlán in 2025 was designed as the starting point rather than the destination. While the event drew hundreds of attendees, Alex Domínguez, co-founder and CMO, says its lasting impact lay in what happened after the weekend ended. The event drew around 300 attendees, 95 percent of them women, along with more than 100 students who took part in an ideathon, though the outcome he dwells on is the one no ledger can capture.

"What we're proudest of isn't a number; it's the sense of community that formed, and the fact that a year later those connections are still active," he said. Many of those who came had never set foot in the town before, and the encounter left an impression that outlasted the weekend. *"For many women, it was their first time discovering Zacatlán, and they fell in love with it,"* he added.





Sury Bonfil, Steph Serrano, Mariana Martín, & Abi Cupido

That sequence, education before infrastructure, is one Revilla returns to whenever the conversation turns to payments, and she is candid that the transactional phase has been kept deliberately slow. The integration of Bitcoin and stablecoin payments is scheduled to begin around the 2026 summit, with wallets still under evaluation and every rollout documented as it happens. She sums up the approach in one promise about the figures the project will publish. *“When we give figures, they will be verifiable,”* she said.

Questions around merchant adoption, regulation, and infrastructure remain, though the team says those are precisely why education comes before implementation.

Can a Bitcoin Economy Actually Work Here?

One of the sharpest questions is how a merchant working on eight to ten percent margins can accept an asset capable of swinging five percent in a day. Abi Cupido, the project's growth director, describes a training program that leaves the decision with the seller, who can convert instantly to pesos for liquidity, move into stablecoins to stay digital without the volatility, or hold only the small share of Bitcoin they do not plan to spend.

“Bitcoin serves different purposes depending on the objective: payment lane, settlement layer or savings asset,” she said, casting market exposure as a risk each participant chooses how much to carry.

Cupido also points to the partners behind the initiative, among them Escuela Bitcoin México for education, the technical providers Aureo and Bull Bitcoin for payments and self-custody, and the

municipal government of Zacatlán, whose backing has opened doors with local businesses.

Can the Zacatlán Model Be Replicated?

Looking past Zacatlán, Revilla is explicit that the town was always intended as a pilot rather than a finish line, one that could eventually be adapted by other communities across Mexico and Latin America if it proves successful. UNLOCK has already confirmed a fourth summit for September 2026 and a fifth for May 2027, both in Zacatlán, and she casts the wider goal in expansive terms. *“The objective is not only for it to work in Zacatlán, but for the model to travel to other Magical Towns in Mexico and Latin America, to the world,”* she said.

Whether it does will depend on something less tangible than events or infrastructure, a point Sury Bonfil, the director of business development, distills into a single condition. *“A model becomes replicable when it empowers local leaders to build communities, create opportunities, and grow the ecosystem from within,”* she said.

The next phase, merchant adoption and real transaction data, will determine whether the educational model translates into a functioning Bitcoin economy. That conviction is personal for those who built the program, among them Mariana Martín, a trader who arrived at an early summit with nine friends and the sentence she still remembers carrying in with her. *“This event can change our relationship with money,”* she said. In a town known for its apple orchards and tourism rather than technology, that idea is no longer theoretical. It is about to be tested.